

One ballot, 120 seats

Learner sheet | 15 minutes | Prepared 2026-10-05

For: Readers new to Israeli elections; pairs or a small discussion group.

Before you start: No prior knowledge. A browser is useful for the linked guides but not required for the exercise.

Learning objectives

- Explain the 3.25% threshold and what happens below it.
- Distinguish an electoral list from a bloc.
- Explain why the largest list does not automatically form a government.

Read together (3 minutes)

Voters choose a ranked electoral list in a single nationwide constituency. There are 120 Knesset seats. An electoral list can contain more than one party; a bloc is a grouping of lists used to describe possible cooperation.

A list must receive at least 3.25% of valid votes to win seats. Votes for a list below the threshold are not transferred to another list. Seats are allocated among the lists that pass.

The largest list does not automatically form the government. Government formation involves a presidential mandate, a proposed governing arrangement and Knesset confidence. An absolute seat majority is 61 of 120; that planning target alone does not establish the legal outcome of a confidence vote.

A fictional ballot (5 minutes)

Assume every vote is valid: List A receives 40%, B receives 30%, C receives 27% and D receives 3%. These are invented lists, not Israeli parties.

1. Which lists pass the threshold? What happens to D's votes?

2. The passing vote shares sum to what percentage? Why should a seat calculation use that passing pool rather than transferring D's votes?

3. A is the largest list. What else would you need to know before saying A will govern?

Explain it to a partner (4 minutes)

1. Finish: A party/list differs from a bloc because...

2. Finish: 61 describes... It does not prove...

3. Name one distinction between national voting eligibility and being affected by a government's decisions. Consult Who votes if you are unsure.

Leave with one question (3 minutes)

1. What would you inspect next: a party's evidence, a coalition's partners or a poll's method? Explain your choice.

Sources and next steps

From votes to seats - source links and method - Facts checked October 5, 2026

<https://www.israelielection.org/how-it-works/seats>

Who votes - citizenship, residency and geography - See the guide's evidence dates

<https://www.israelielection.org/how-it-works/who-votes>

Forming a government - legal process - See the guide's evidence dates

<https://www.israelielection.org/how-it-works/forming-a-government>

Israel Democracy Institute - the electoral system - March 16, 2026

<https://en.idi.org.il/articles/63750>

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